



FREE GUIDE

RANK HIGHER WITHOUT US.

The exact steps we run for paying clients, written so a business owner can do them alone. No course, no upsell sequence. If you follow this and never call us, it worked.

SXO · SEO · AEO · GEO · AIO

READ THIS FIRST

WHY WE ARE GIVING YOU THE WHOLE THING.

Most agencies hand out a guide that stops right before the part that works. Ours does not. Everything in here is what we actually run for paying clients, in the order we run it, with the tools named and the settings spelled out.

We can afford to do that because the steps were never the secret. The work is the secret. Every chapter here ends with an honest count of the hours it takes to do properly and to keep doing every month, and that number is the whole reason our clients pay us instead of doing this themselves.

So read it, run it, and if the hours add up to something you can carry, you should absolutely keep the money. If they do not, you will know exactly what you are hiring for and exactly what it should cost.

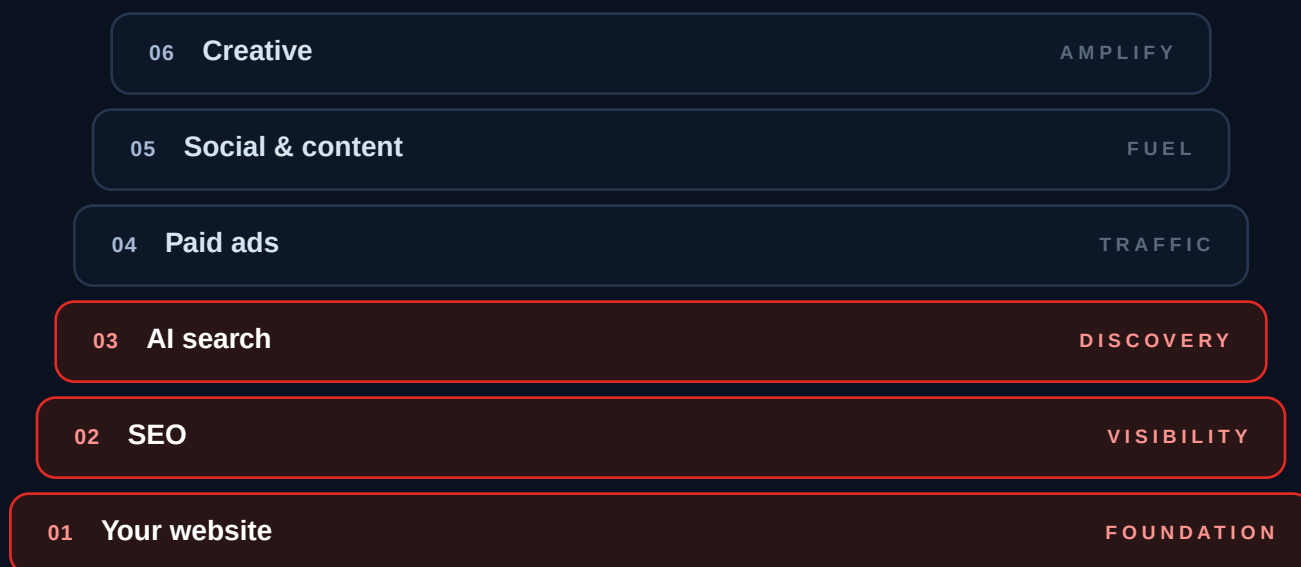
Zac Sweat

Founder, Open Heart Media

THE ORDER

DOING THESE IN THE WRONG ORDER IS HOW BUDGETS DISAPPEAR.

Five disciplines, and they are not parallel. Each one only works once the one under it is in place. This guide covers the bottom three layers of the engine below, because those are the layers a business owner can genuinely run alone. Ads, social and creative sit on top and are a different conversation.



Highlighted layers are what this guide teaches you to run yourself.

CONTENTS

THE FIVE DISCIPLINES.

- 01 SXO** Search experience optimization
The site itself. Everything else delivers here, so it goes first.

- 02 SEO** Search engine optimization
Ranking on Google. Still the base layer every AI engine reads.

- 03 AEO** Answer engine optimization
Being the answer inside AI Overviews and AI Mode, not just a blue link.

- 04 GEO** Generative engine optimization
Getting named when someone asks ChatGPT, Perplexity or Gemini who to hire.

- 05 AIO** AI optimization
What the models already believe about your business, and how to correct it.

HOW TO USE THIS

Do not read it all at once and do nothing. Pick chapter one, block four hours this week, and finish it. A finished chapter one beats five chapters skimmed. Each chapter is written so you can run it start to finish without the others.

SXO: THE SITE EVERYTHING LANDS ON

Search experience optimization is the part almost everyone skips, which is why almost everyone wastes money on the other four. Every channel you will ever run, organic, paid, social, AI, ends at your website. If that page is slow, confusing, or gives a ready buyer no obvious way to act, then every dollar and every hour you spend upstream is buying a more expensive version of the same nothing.

Fix this first. It is also the only layer here where the improvement is immediate and permanent.

What good actually means

- Loads and becomes usable in under 2.5 seconds on a phone on cell data, not on your office wifi.
- Your phone number is a tap-to-call link, not text somebody has to copy.
- What you do and where you do it is legible in the first screen, without scrolling.
- A lead form that is three fields, not eleven, and that works when a field is left blank.
- One clear next action per page. Not four competing buttons.

Run it yourself

1 Test it the way a customer does

Open your own site on your phone, on cell data, with wifi off. Time it. Try to call yourself from it. Try to submit the form.

Then run it through Google PageSpeed Insights (pagespeed.web.dev) and read the MOBILE tab, not desktop. Desktop scores flatter you and nobody is buying from a desktop at 7pm.

Write down every number you get. You need the before to prove the after.

2 Kill the weight

Images are almost always the problem. Export everything at the size it is actually displayed and convert to WebP. A 4MB hero photo is a 4MB hero photo on cell data too.

Remove plugins, chat widgets, tracking scripts and fonts you are not using. Every one is a request that has to finish before someone sees your page.

Serve one web font, two weights maximum.

3 Make the action obvious

Put a tap-to-call button in the header, sticky on mobile. The markup is a link with tel: and your number.

Cut the contact form to name, phone, and one free-text field. Every extra field measurably costs you submissions.

Say what you do and what county you serve above the fold, in plain words a neighbor would use.

4

Prove it converts

Install Google Analytics 4 and set up a conversion event on form submit and on tap-to-call. Without this you are guessing forever.

Add Microsoft Clarity. It is free and it records real sessions, so you can watch where people give up.

Check both weekly for a month before you change anything else.

THE CHEAPEST WIN IN THIS ENTIRE GUIDE

If your phone number is not a tap-to-call link on mobile, fix that today. It takes ten minutes and for most local businesses it is the single highest-return change in this document.

THE REAL TIME COST

To audit, compress, restructure and instrument one small business site properly the first time. Then roughly 1 to 2 hours a month to keep it from creeping back up as you add pages, photos and plugins.

12-20 hrs

SEO: GETTING FOUND ON GOOGLE

SEO has not died and AI has not replaced it. Every answer engine in this guide is still reading the same open web, and the signals that make Google trust you are the same signals that make a model quote you. Do this layer badly and the next three cannot work.

Run it yourself

1 Own your Google Business Profile

Claim it, verify it, and complete every field. For a local business this outranks your website for most searches that matter.

Categories are the highest-leverage field. Set the primary category to exactly what you are, then add every genuinely accurate secondary.

Post to it weekly. Photos of real jobs, not stock. Google measurably favours active profiles.

Ask for reviews on the day the work finishes, in person, by name. Reply to every one, including the bad ones, without arguing.

2 Find the words people actually use

Do not guess. Type your service into Google and read the People Also Ask box and the autocomplete suggestions. That is free query data straight from the source.

Ask an AI model to list the questions a homeowner asks before hiring your trade. Then check each one in Google to confirm real people search it.

Build a plain spreadsheet: the question, roughly how often it comes up, and whether you have a page answering it. Almost every row will be empty. That is your content plan.

3 One page per thing you do, per place you do it

A single Services page listing eight services will lose to eight competitors who each have a dedicated page.

Same for towns. If you serve six towns, you need six genuinely different pages, each with real local detail. Copy-pasted town pages with the name swapped get you penalized, and rightly so.

Each page needs one clear topic, a descriptive title tag under 60 characters, and an H1 that matches what the page is about.

4 Fix the technical basics once

Set up Google Search Console. It is free and it tells you exactly which searches you already appear for.

Submit a sitemap. Confirm your important pages are indexed and no important page is accidentally blocked.

Add LocalBusiness structured data with your name, address, phone, hours and service area. This is also what feeds the AI layers later.

5 Publish something useful every week

Take one row from your spreadsheet and answer it properly in 600 to 1,000 words. Written by you, in your voice, with the specifics only somebody who does the work would know.

Answer the question in the first paragraph. Do not make people scroll past your origin story.

Link it to the relevant service page and the relevant town page.

CHECK WHO OWNS YOUR ACCOUNTS

Log into Search Console and Google Business Profile and look at who else has owner access. Previous agencies leave themselves on there constantly. If someone other than you owns your listing, fix that before anything else in this chapter.

THE REAL TIME COST

To claim and complete the profile, do the keyword research honestly, build out the service and location pages and fix the technical base. Then 6 to 10 hours every month, forever, for the weekly publishing and review cadence. The monthly number is the one that ends most DIY attempts around week seven.

20-30 hrs

AEO: BEING THE ANSWER, NOT A LINK

When someone searches now, Google increasingly answers them directly at the top of the page. If that answer is drawn from a competitor, the click never happens and your ranking stopped mattering. Answer engine optimization is the work of being the source that gets pulled into the answer.

What these engines are looking for

- A direct answer stated plainly, early, in one or two sentences.
- Structure a machine can parse: real headings, real lists, real tables, not a wall of text.
- Specificity. Numbers, timeframes, named materials, actual prices where you can give them.
- Something a model cannot get anywhere else. Generic content is not worth citing.

Run it yourself

1 Write the answer first, then the article

Structure every page as: the question as an H2, then a 40 to 60 word direct answer immediately beneath it, then the detail.

That opening block is what gets lifted. If your answer is buried in paragraph six it will not be found.

2 Build a real FAQ, from real calls

For two weeks, write down every question a customer actually asks on the phone. That list is worth more than any keyword tool.

Answer each one on your site in plain language, one question per heading.

Add FAQPage structured data so the questions and answers are machine-readable.

3 Give numbers, not adjectives

'Fast response' is worth nothing. 'We answer calls within 15 minutes during business hours, and same day after' is quotable.

Ranges beat silence on price. 'Most asphalt roof replacements in Cherokee County run \$9,000 to \$16,000 depending on pitch and layers' will be cited. 'Contact us for a quote' never will.

4 Mark up everything you can

LocalBusiness, Service, FAQPage and Review schema. Google's Rich Results Test validates it free.

Keep your name, address and phone identical everywhere on the internet. Inconsistency here quietly undermines all of it.

THE REAL TIME COST

To restructure existing pages into answer-first format, build the FAQ from real calls and implement schema. Then 3 to 5 hours a month to keep adding questions as they come in. The two weeks of call logging is the part nobody does, and it is the part that makes the difference.

15-25 hrs

GEO: GETTING NAMED BY THE AI

A growing number of buyers now open ChatGPT or Perplexity and ask who they should hire. Those models do not rank pages the way Google does. They synthesize from sources they consider trustworthy, and being invisible to them is a channel you are losing without ever seeing it in your analytics.

Run it yourself

1 Find out what they say about you today

Open ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini and Google AI Mode. Ask each one: 'Who are the best [your trade] in [your town]?' and 'Tell me about [your business name].'

Screenshot every answer. If you are not mentioned, that is your baseline. If you are mentioned wrongly, that is chapter five.

Repeat this monthly. It is the only tracking that exists for this right now and it costs you fifteen minutes.

2 Get cited where models actually look

These models lean heavily on third-party sources they trust: local news, industry directories, trade association listings, chamber of commerce pages, and genuine review sites.

Get listed in every legitimate directory for your trade and your county. Not link farms. Real ones your peers are in.

Pitch one genuinely useful local story to your local paper or a trade publication a year. One good citation outperforms fifty directory listings.

3 Publish the thing only you could write

Models cite sources that contain information not available elsewhere. Original data is the strongest form of this.

You already have it. What you charged across 40 jobs last year. How long a repair actually lasts in Georgia humidity. What fails first on a 15-year-old install. Publish that, with the numbers.

This is the single most effective and least practiced thing in this entire guide.

4 Be consistently described

Write one clear sentence describing your business and use it identically everywhere: your site, your profile, every directory, every social bio.

Models build confidence from repetition across independent sources. Five different descriptions of you reads as five weak signals instead of one strong one.

WHY THIS ONE COMPOUNDS

Directories and citations take months to be absorbed and then persist. The businesses that start this in 2026 will be the defaults these models reach for in 2028, and displacing an established default is far harder than becoming one.

THE REAL TIME COST

To audit what the models currently say, build out legitimate citations and publish your first piece of genuinely original data. Then 2 to 4 hours a month to keep testing and keep adding. The original-data piece is the heavy lift and it is the one that works.

10-18 hrs

AIO: CORRECTING WHAT THE MODELS BELIEVE

The last layer is not about being found. It is about being described accurately once you are. Models absorb whatever the open web says about you, including things that are outdated, half-true, or somebody else's business with a similar name. Most owners have never checked, and a confidently wrong answer costs you more than no answer at all.

Run it yourself

1 Audit what is out there

Ask each model to describe your business, list your services, give your hours and say what area you serve. Note every error.

Common ones: an old address, a phone number from two owners ago, services you dropped years ago, or being confused with a similarly named company in another state.

2 Correct it at the source

Models do not have a correction form. You fix the sources they read.

Update every directory listing, every old profile, every social account you forgot you had. Claim or close the abandoned ones.

If an old address or number exists anywhere on the internet, it will keep resurfacing until you remove it.

3 Publish the definitive version

Make one page on your own site the canonical source: legal name, address, phone, hours, service area, full service list, founding year, credentials and licence numbers.

Mark it up with structured data. This gives the models something authoritative and unambiguous to prefer.

4 Re-check on a schedule

Put a recurring 30-minute block in your calendar every month. Ask the same questions, compare to last month, log what changed.

This layer drifts. Something you corrected in March can come back in July from a source you missed.

THE REAL TIME COST

For the initial audit and cleanup, more if your business has changed name, address or ownership at any point. Then 1 to 2 hours a month of re-checking, indefinitely, because it drifts.

6-12 hrs

PUT IT IN ORDER

THE FIRST 90 DAYS.

If you do one thing with this guide, do this. Everything is sequenced so each block makes the next one work.

WEEKS 1-2

Fix the foundation

Speed, tap-to-call, cut the form, install GA4 and Clarity. Record your before numbers.

WEEKS 3-4

Own your listing

Claim and complete Google Business Profile. Set categories. Start the weekly post and review habit.

WEEKS 5-6

Find the questions

Log every question customers ask on the phone. Build the spreadsheet. Set up Search Console.

WEEKS 7-9

Build the pages

One page per service, one per town. Answer-first structure. Add schema.

WEEKS 10-11

Get cited

Audit what the models say. Fix the wrong entries. Build legitimate directory citations.

WEEK 12

Publish your data

One original piece only you could write, with real numbers from your own jobs.

WHAT THIS ACTUALLY COSTS YOU

Here is the arithmetic we promised at the front. These are real numbers from running this for real clients, not a scare tactic. Add them up before you decide anything.

DISCIPLINE	TO SET UP	EVERY MONTH
01 SXO	12-20 hrs	1-2 hrs
02 SEO	20-30 hrs	6-10 hrs
03 AEO	15-25 hrs	3-5 hrs
04 GEO	10-18 hrs	2-4 hrs
05 AIO	6-12 hrs	1-2 hrs
TOTAL	63-105 hrs	13-23 hrs

Roughly two to three full working weeks to set up, and then somewhere between two and three days out of every single month, indefinitely, to keep it alive. Not in one block either. It is spread across weekly publishing, weekly posting, review replies and monthly checks, which is exactly the shape of work that loses to a busy season.

You should do this yourself if

- You have or can protect 10 to 20 hours a month, every month, including your busiest one.
- You genuinely enjoy this kind of work, because unenjoyable work is the first thing dropped.
- You are early enough that your time is worth less than the fee.

You should hire someone if

- Your billable hour is worth more than what the monthly work would cost you to buy.
- You have tried before and stalled around week six or seven. Almost everyone does, and it is a scheduling problem, not a discipline problem.
- You want the five layers running at once instead of sequentially over a year.

EITHER WAY, YOU WIN

If you run this yourself and it works, you got a full playbook for free and you should keep the money. If you run it and stall, you now know precisely what you are buying, what it should cost, and what questions to ask anyone who pitches you. That is worth more than another sales call.



IF YOU WANT IT RUN FOR YOU

WE BUILT THE ENGINE. YOU PICK THE DAY.

We are eleven people in Canton, Georgia running all five of these layers for local businesses across North Georgia. Most of our clients have been with us for years, some since we started in 2022. Agreements are a six month minimum, because anything shorter is not enough time to prove the work.

Start with the free audit. We look at all five layers on your actual business and hand you the findings whether you hire us or not.

Get my free growth audit

go.openheartmediaco.com/go